

Persian, Step by Step, Root by Root

A gentle, etymology-driven introduction to Iranian Persian

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Starter edition — ten short lessons in three cumulative chapters.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at
code/learning/human-languages/persian/lessons/

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How to use this starter edition

Begin with no assumed Persian. Each section takes one small expression, teaches only the letters and grammar needed for it, connects it to words you may already know, and ends with a short retrieval prompt. Read the Persian from right to left, but do not memorize an alphabet before you meet useful language.

This volume teaches contemporary Iranian Persian. Romanization remains beside the script in this starter edition and will fade gradually. Formal written and colloquial Iranian forms will be labelled when they diverge; Dari and Tajik are related future tracks, not silent substitutes.

Persian vocabulary has several historical layers. Some everyday words are inherited Iranian forms; many others came through Arabic and now follow Persian pronunciation and grammar. The point of etymology here is practical: it makes a word easier to remember without replacing its present meaning or use.

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Chapter 1

Greetings and responses

This chapter builds one miniature exchange in dependency order: greet, thank, answer yes, answer no. Four short expressions are enough to establish the direction of the script, joining, one non-joining letter, omitted short vowels, and the contrast between borrowed and inherited vocabulary. Companion lessons: FA-C01-*.md.

1.1 سلام (*salâm*) — hello through peace

Read only what this expression needs

Persian runs **right to left**. Read سلام from its right edge: س *s*, ل *l*, ا long *â*, م *m*. Most letters join inside a word. The tall ا is a non-joiner on its left side, so the final م begins a new stroke group. No other letters are required yet.

Where the expression came from

Salâm means “hello” and evokes peace. Persian borrowed it from Arabic, whose consonant family **s-l-m** carries ideas of peace, safety, and wholeness. Hebrew *shalom* belongs to the same older Semitic family. The word is borrowed history and completely ordinary modern Persian at once.

Use it now

Say سلام to one person or a group. It is a neutral, friendly greeting. Hear it, answer with the same word, and resist adding any grammar yet.

One-minute checkpoint

Read سلام from right to left. Which letter carries the long *â*? Point to ل, cover the romanization, and say *salâm* once.

1.2 ممنون (*mamnun*) — thank you**Read only what this expression needs**

Reuse final م from سلام, now at the right edge where reading begins. The visible sequence is م *m*, م *m*, ن *n*, و long *u*, ن *n*. Persian usually omits short vowels, so the first *a* is learned with the whole word. Here و carries the long *u*.

Where the expression came from

Persian received *mamnun* from Arabic. It describes someone as grateful or obliged and belongs to the Arabic **m–n–n** family associated with favor or kindness. In current Persian conversation, the whole word is simply a useful “thanks.”

Use it now

Build the smallest exchange: A says سلام; B answers سلام; A adds ممنون. Treat each expression as one social move.

One-minute checkpoint

Which visible letter carries long *u* in ممنون? Point to و, then say *salâm* — *mamnun* without looking.

1.3 بله (*bale*) — yes**Read only what this expression needs**

Read three letters: ب *b*, ل *l*, ه *h*. The short *a* and *e* are supplied by the reader rather than written as separate letters. The final ه remains visible even though careful speech ends with a light vowel-like sound rather than a forceful English *h*.

Use it now

Bale is a standard polite affirmative. A more casual answer exists, but one reliable “yes” is enough now: *bale*, *mamnun* — yes, thank you.

One-minute checkpoint

Cover *bale*. Read بله; name the two short vowels that the writing leaves implicit; answer “yes” once.

1.4 نه (*na*) — no, and an inherited bridge**Read only what this expression needs**

You already know final ه from بله and ن from ممنون. Put ن on the right and read نه: *n* plus an unwritten short *a*.

Where the expression came from

Unlike the two Arabic loans at the start of this chapter, Persian *na* continues an old Indo-Iranian negative family. Related forms occur across Iranian and Indo-Aryan languages. This is the first bridge from Persian toward Hindi and Urdu: not an instruction to learn those forms now, just a reason the tiny word may feel familiar later.

Use it now

Contrast only the answer: بله *bale* — yes; نه *na* — no. Ask yourself a harmless yes/no question and answer it both ways.

One-minute checkpoint

Without looking back, produce the four-step chain: hello, thank you, yes, no. Then read سلام, ممنون, بله, نه in the same order.

Chapter 2

Give your name

The first chapter supplied social moves. This one adds a single sentence and a single grammar idea: Persian's linking vowel, *ezafe*. Companion lesson: FA-C02-esm-e-man.md.

2.1 اسم من ... است (*esm-e man ... ast*) — my name is ...

Read the Persian phrase from right to left while keeping its spoken word order:

اسم من سارا است
esm-e man Sârâ ast — My name is Sara.

Read only what this expression needs

The phrase reuses more than it appears to. In اسم *esm*, you already recognize ا, س, and م. In من *man*, both letters came from ممنون. The final word است *ast* begins with familiar ا and س; only ت *t* is new. Short vowels remain mostly implicit.

Use it now

Assemble four pieces:

1. اسم *esm* — name;
2. a spoken *-e* — the linker called **ezafe**;
3. من *man* — I/me, interpreted here as the owner;
4. your name, followed by است *ast* — is.

Only one reusable pattern is due: **noun + -e + owner**. Do not expand it into a table of possessive grammar yet.

Where the expression came from

The sentence displays two historical layers side by side. *Esm* is an Arabic loan related to Arabic *ism*. *Man* and *ast* belong to Persian's inherited Iranian core. Borrowed nouns and inherited grammar now work together as one Persian sentence.

One-minute checkpoint

What links *esm* to *man*? Say the normally unwritten *-e*. Then replace Sara with your own name and produce the full careful sentence once.

What is deliberately deferred

Everyday speech often shortens the final copula, and Persian has familiar and polite ways to ask another person's name. Those are later lessons. Keeping the full است visible here lets a new reader account for every part before conversational reductions begin.

Chapter 3

Ask and Answer Names

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

3.1 شما / تو — two relationships inside “you”

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Say **esm-e man ... ast** with your own name. To turn that sentence around, you next need a safe word for the other person.

The two words

Persian	read	use
شما	<i>shomâ</i>	one person respectfully, or more than one person
تو	<i>to</i>	one familiar person

In شما, meet ش *sh*; its three dots distinguish it from س *s*. Final ا carries long *â*. In تو, و has its *o* value rather than the long *u* it had in ممنون. Learn the sound from the whole word.

Grammar Lens: begin respectfully

Persian uses plural **shomâ** for respectful singular address, much as Russian uses *vy* and French uses *vous*. Use **shomâ** with an unfamiliar adult or in a first meeting. Use **to** after the relationship is familiar. English once made a similar distinction but now uses *you* for both.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Persian **to** belongs to the ancient Indo-European familiar-“you” family: English **thou**, Latin *tū*, and Sanskrit *tvam* are relatives. The word is old; the social choice carried by it is current.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: a new adult — **shomâ**]
- [YOU SAY: a close friend — **to**]
- [YOU SAY: the old family — **to, thou, tū, tvam**]

Wrap-up recall

Which form is safest when the relationship is new? (**Shomâ**.) Which is the relative of English *thou*? (**To**.)
Source: Persian Online: Pronouns.

3.2 چیست — “what is?” in one joined word

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Which “you” is safe for a new adult? (شما, *shomâ*.) Now add the question engine that will follow “your name.”

You’ll want to know first — چیست

چیست — *chist* — **what is?**

Read from the right: چ *ch*, ی long *i*, س *s*, ت *t*. چ is one of Persian’s four additions to the Arabic alphabet: it uses the same base shape as چ, with three dots below. Meet only this joined form now.

Grammar Lens: two words compressed

chist is the careful fusion of **chi** “what” and **ast** “is.” The opening vowel of *ast* disappears when the pieces join:

chi + ast → **chist**

You already know full **ast** from *esm-e man ... ast*. This lesson changes no copula rule; it gives one high-frequency fused question form.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: **chi** + **ast** → **chist**]
- [YOU READ: چیست from چ to ت]
- [YOU SAY: **chist?** — “what is?”]

Wrap-up recall

What two pieces make **chist**? (**Chi** + **ast**.) Which new Persian letter opens it? (چ, *ch*, with three dots below.)

3.3 چیست؟ شما اسم — ask a name respectfully

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Give the three ready pieces: **esm-e** “name-of,” **shomâ** respectful “you,” and **chist** “what is?”

The exchange

چيست؟ شما اسم — *esm-e shomâ chist?* — **What is your name?**

The Persian order is transparent once the pieces are known:

name + **-e** + you + what-is?

The spoken ezafe turns **esm-e shomâ** into “your name.” **Chist** stays at the end. No new agreement or verb table is hiding here.

Script: the question mark

Persian ends a written question with ؟. Its curve faces the opposite way from English ?, matching the right-to-left line. Read the sentence from its right edge; meet the punctuation at the far left.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: **esm-e shomâ chist?**]
- [YOU SAY: ask, then answer — **esm-e man ... ast**]
- [YOU POINT: to ؟ at the end of the right-to-left question]

Wrap-up recall

Ask the question once without reading the romanization. Then answer with the careful name frame you already know.

Source: Persian Online: Introducing Yourself.

3.4 خوشوقتم — pleased to meet you

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Ask **esm-e shomâ chist?** and answer **esm-e man ... ast.** One warm response now closes that tiny meeting.

The exchange

خوشوقتم — *khoshvaghtam* — **Pleased to meet you.**

Treat the joined word as one social move first. خ gives *kh*, like the sound in Scottish *loch*. ش gives *sh*. Persian commonly pronounces ق here with the merged *gh/q* sound of contemporary Iranian speech.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **khosh** — pleasant, happy; inherited Persian vocabulary.
- **vaqt** (pronounced *vaght* here) — time; an Arabic loan fully at home in Persian.
- **-am** — I am, the first-person ending.

So the word builds “pleasant-time-I-am” into the idiomatic feeling “I am pleased.” The history is layered; the expression is ordinary modern Persian.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: **khoshvaghtam** as one smooth response]
- [YOU SAY: the three pieces — **khosh** + **vaqt** + **-am**]
- [YOU SAY: which piece came from Arabic — **vaqt**]

Wrap-up recall

Which response closes the introduction? (**Khoshvaghtam**.) Which three layers can you hear inside it? (**Khosh + vaqt + -am**.)

Source: Persian Online: Introducing Yourself.

3.5 Practice — a complete Persian name exchange

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Recall the four moves without adding anything: greet, ask, answer, acknowledge.

The exchange

A: سلام! — *Salâm!* B: سلام! — *Salâm!* A: چیست؟ شما اسم —
Esm-e shomâ chist? B: است سارا من اسم. — *Esm-e man Sârâ*
ast. A: خوشوقتم. — *Khoshvaghtam.* B: ممنون. — *Mamnun.*

Every line is already known. **Shomâ** keeps the first meeting respectful; the answer returns to **man**. The question mark sits at the left end of the right-to-left question.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: both voices, using your own name]
- [YOU SAY: the exchange again without romanization]
- [YOU SAY: only the three name moves — question, answer, response]

Wrap-up recall

Run the meeting once from **salâm** to **mamnun**. If one line stalls, review that single micro-lesson rather than rereading the whole chapter.

Sources for this starter edition

Script descriptions follow the University of Texas at Austin Persian Online writing-system materials. The companion Markdown lessons are the canonical short-practice source for this edition.